playing. That it wasn't my job to be a right-back. I should be pushing up, further forward, he said. I couldn't understand what he meant. I looked across at Gary who, of course, was playing behind me, and I could see he didn't agree with him either. There wasn't any point in me saying anything. We were only 1–0 down and we had 45 minutes, now, to put things right.

It got worse, though. Early in the second half, Edu played a through ball for Wiltord and Arsenal were two up. I didn't play well. Nobody else did, either. We trooped back into the dressing room afterwards. I took my boots and shin pads off straight away because I'd got a kick on my leg and had been substituted. The boss came in, shut the door, took his jacket off and hung it up on a hook. His first words were:

'David. What about the second goal? What were you doing?'

Was he blaming me? I was taken completely by surprise.

'It wasn't my fault. Their bloke made a run off someone in central midfield.'

The boss kept going: 'We told you about it before the game. The problem with you is you don't let anyone talk to you. You don't listen.'

I couldn't believe it. I'd been listening—and wanting to listen—my whole career. I'd listened to the boss since the first day we'd met and I was listening now.

'David. When you're wrong, you've got to own up.'

'Boss, I'm sorry. I'm not wrong here. This wasn't my fault and I'm not taking the blame for it.'

'No. Take the blame is what you're going to do.'

Everybody in the dressing room could hear what was going on. Surely, everybody else knew I was right: you could have pointed your finger at half a dozen of the team in the build-up to Arsenal's second goal.

But it was all down to me, according to the boss. I felt like I was being bullied, in public, and being backed into a corner, for no reason other than spite. I was trapped. And I swore at him. Something no player, certainly no United player, should ever do to the manager. What happened then still doesn't seem real now, thinking back to that afternoon.